armed forces grew in strength. Lebanon had become the main focus of their military operations against Israel and they received a constant stream of recruits from the 400,000 Palestinians in the refugee camps in Lebanon.

Key date
Israeli invasions of Lebanon: 1978 and 1982

'Operation Peace for Galilee' 1982

In the early months of 1982 the Israelis planned another invasion of Lebanon, to be called 'Operation Peace for Galilee'. They simply needed a pretext. This came in June 1982 when a group of Palestinians attempted to murder the Israeli ambassador in London. Those responsible were extremists, opposed to Yasser Arafat, but that made no difference to the Israelis. This was the trigger they needed. Israeli forces again rolled across the Lebanese border. This time they had 170,000 troops, 3500 tanks and 600 fighter planes. The UN peacekeeping forces were powerless to stop them. The Israelis were more successful in destroying PLO forces than they had been in 1978. However, thousands of Palestinian and Lebanese civilians were killed in the process and hundreds of thousands were made homeless.

The Israeli Minister of Defence, Ariel Sharon, told the Israeli Prime Minister and his cabinet that the aim was to drive out the Palestinian forces, destroy their bases and establish a 40-km security zone in southern Lebanon in order to protect the Israelis living in Galilee. However, it soon became obvious that Sharon was far more ambitious because the Israelis advanced north and surrounded the capital, Beirut (see the map on page 77). They cut off supplies of food and water. They started shelling positions in the city which were held by the PLO. These positions were often in crowded residential areas so thousands more civilians were killed. As well as encircling Beirut on land, the Israelis had complete control of the sky and the coastline. Beirut was bombarded daily, from air, land and sea, for two months. On one day alone in August 1982 there were 127 air raids launched on the city. Over 20,000 people were killed and many more wounded during the 'Battle of Beirut'.

Key question
How was the siege of Baghdad ended?

The evacuation of the PLO

Eventually, in mid-August, the USA intervened. The Americans persuaded the Israelis to stop shelling the city in return for an agreement that the PLO fighters would be evacuated. US, French and Italian troops were sent out to supervise the evacuation. Over 14,000 Palestinian fighters left Beirut to travel to other Arab states. Yasser Arafat, the last to leave, moved his headquarters to Tunisia.

The Americans had assured Arafat that Palestinian civilians would not be harmed after the PLO forces left Beirut. However, the Israelis believed that there were still 2000 Palestinian fighters left in the refugee camps of Sabra and Shatila in Beirut. When on 14 September the newly elected Christian President of Lebanon was killed, his armed supporters took their revenge. They invaded the refugee camps and, over the next two days, they carried out a massacre of men, women and children. The Israeli